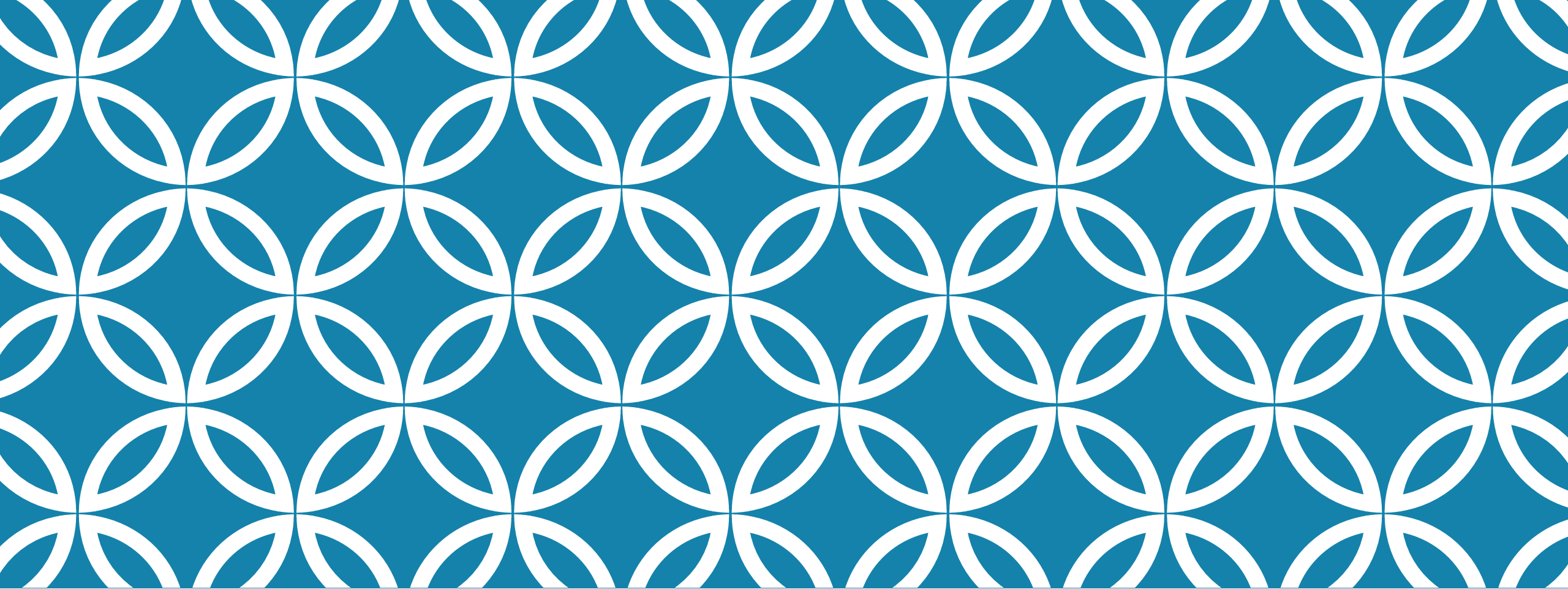




# AN OVERVIEW OF TECHNICAL AND BUSINESS WRITING

# TECHNICAL COMMUNICATION

First thing is first, what is Technical writing?

Time for some boring definitions...

# TECHNICAL COMMUNICATION

Oral and written communication for and about business and industry.

Technical and business writers **Take complicated subject matter and transform it into easy-to-understand information for the reader.**

Michael Markel gives the following definition:

"Technical writing conveys **specific information** about a **technical subject** to a **specific audience** for a **specific purpose**."



THERE IS MORE...

**Technical writing** is the written communication of business or scientific ideas, concepts, and data presented **objectively, logically, and accurately**. The writing is **clear** and **concise**. **Graphics** are usually included to assist the reader in understanding the subject matter. The reader should be convinced of the conclusions based on the information presented. The recipient will usually use the report or document **to perform a task, make a decision, solve a problem, or acquire information and knowledge**.

## DIFFERENT TYPES OF WRITING

| Type      | Purpose                 | Writer         | Audience                       |
|-----------|-------------------------|----------------|--------------------------------|
| Academic  | Display Knowledge       | Student        | Teachers / Colleagues          |
| Personal  | Enlighten/<br>Entertain | Friend         | Friends<br>(yourself)          |
| Technical | Get something done      | Skilled expert | Managers / Workers / Customers |

# PURPOSES OF TECHNICAL COMMUNICATION

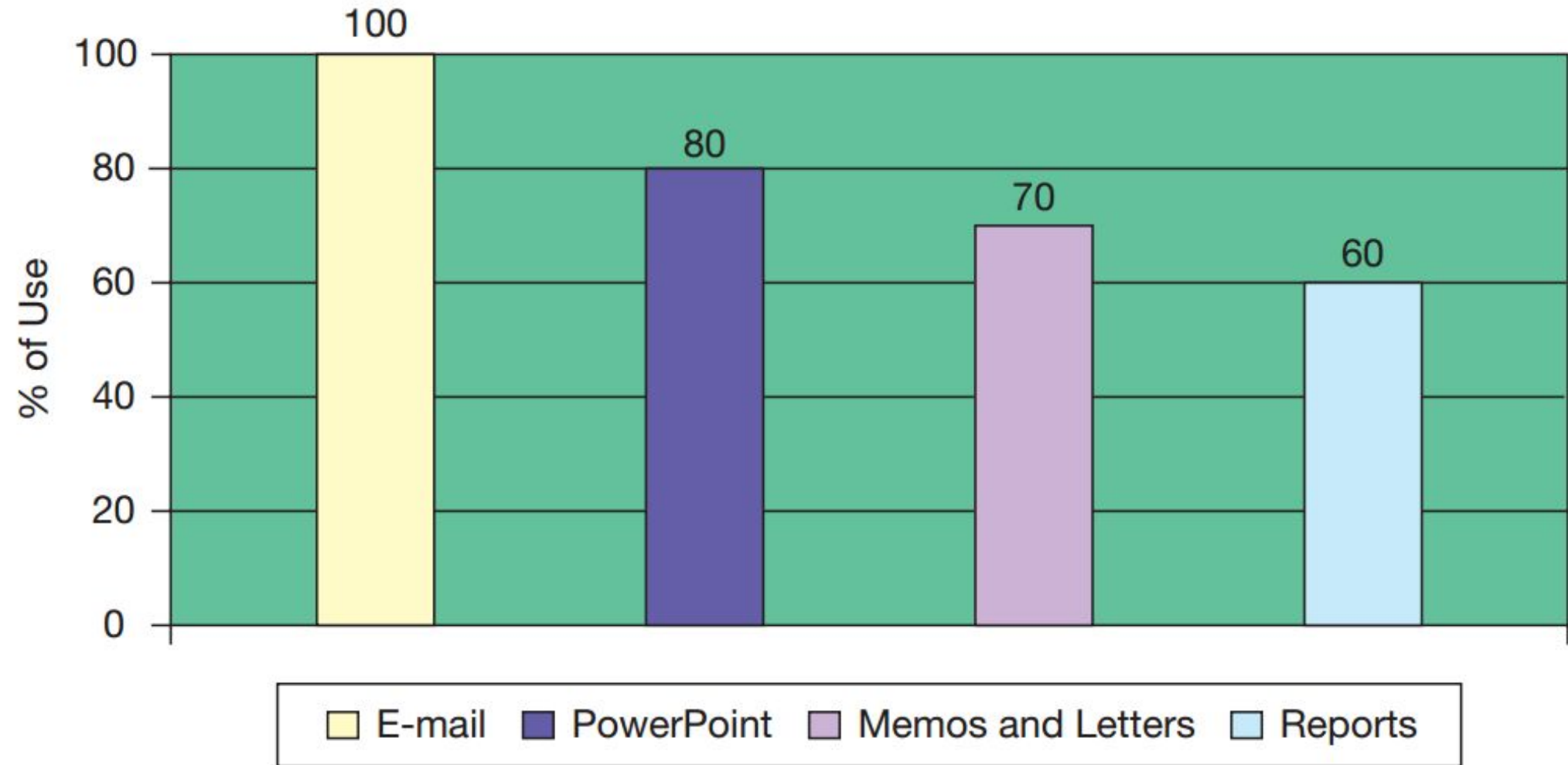
You will communicate to different audiences, for different purposes, using different channels of communication.



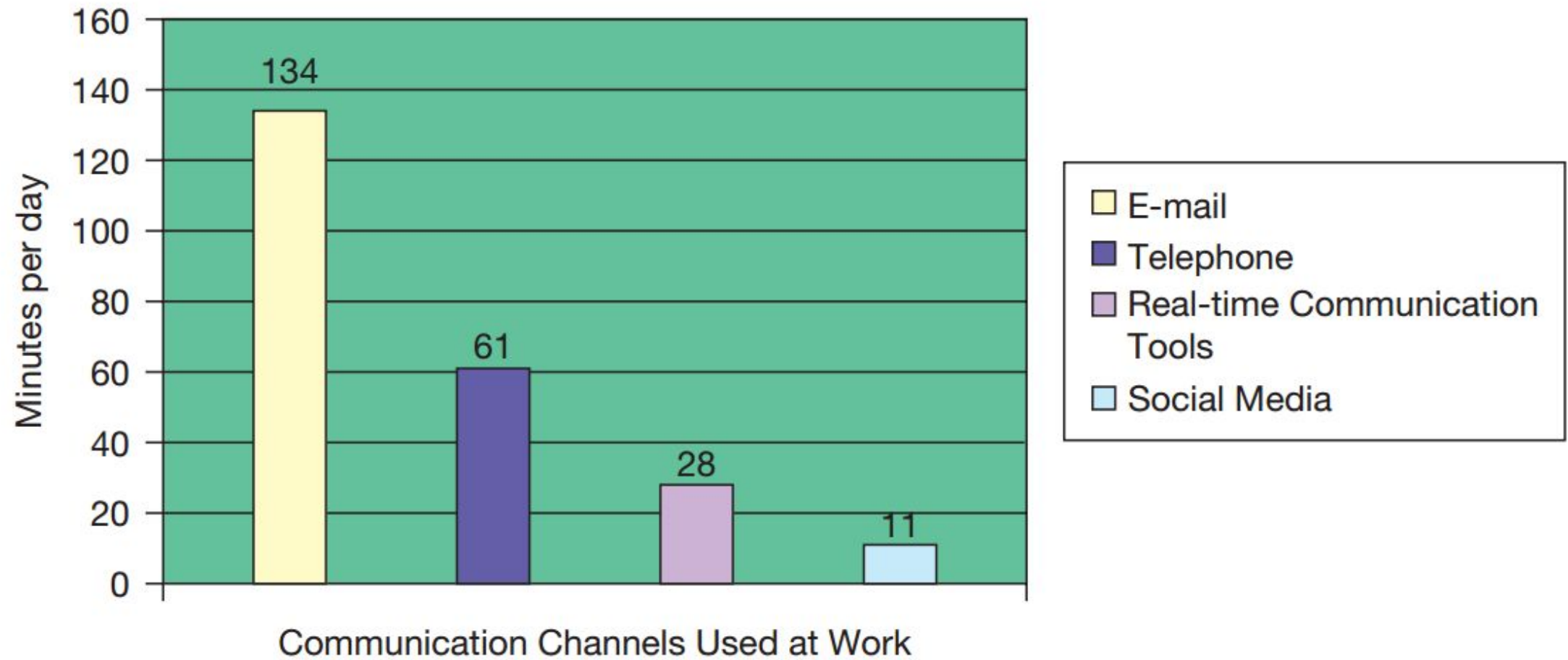
To succeed on the job, you need to  
write and speak effectively to  
others—constantly.



**FIGURE 1** Channels "Almost Always" Used in Workplace Communication

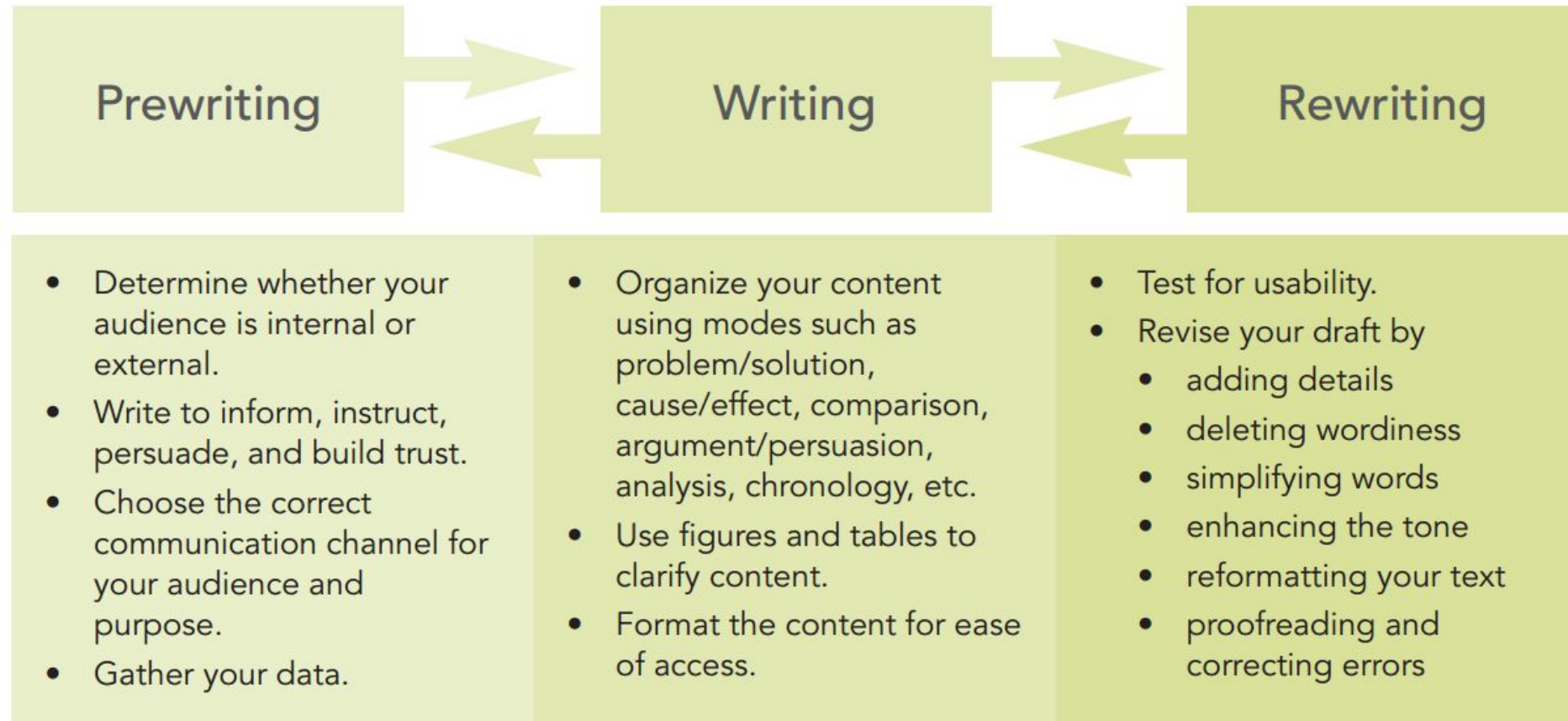


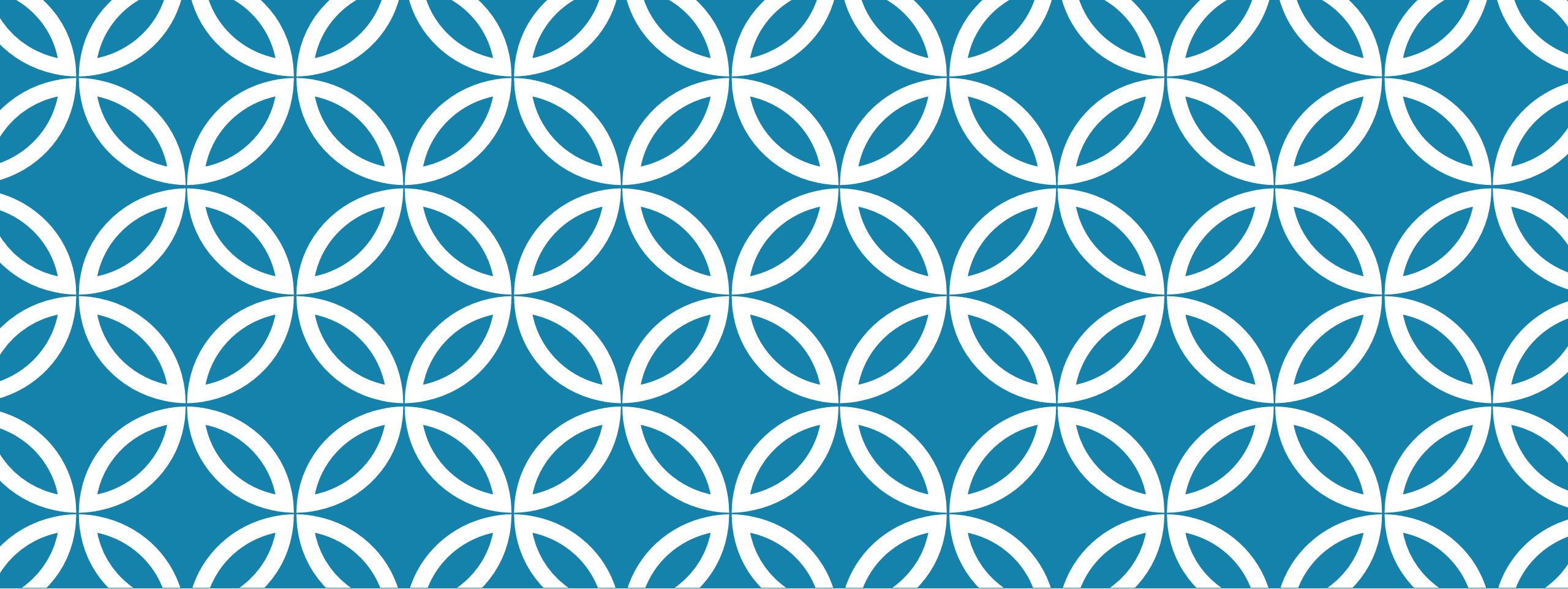
**FIGURE 2** Time Spent Communicating on the Job



# THE TECHNICAL WRITING PROCESS IN A NUTSHELL

## The Writing Process





# OBJECTIVES IN TECHNICAL COMMUNICATION



# 1. CLARITY

The ultimate goal of good technical communication is clarity

# CLARITY

Clarity is key in technical communication

To achieve clarity supply specific, quantified information

Pro tip: avoid using words like recently (adverb), some (adjective) and many (adjective).

# CONTINUED

## BEFORE

Our latest attempt at molding preform protectors has led to some positive results. We spent several hours in Dept. 15 trying different machine settings and techniques. Several good parts were molded using two different sheet thicknesses. Here's a summary of the findings.

First, we tried the thick sheet material. At 240°F, this thickness worked well. Next, we tried the thinner sheet material. The thinner material is less forgiving, but after a few adjustments we were making good parts. Still, the thin material caused the most handling problems.



# CONTINUED

## AFTER

During the week of 10/4/12, we spent approximately 12 hours in Dept. 15 trying different machine settings, techniques, and thicknesses to mold preform mold protectors. Here is a report on our findings:

- 0.030" Thick Sheet

At 240°F, this thickness worked well.

- 0.015" Thick Sheet

This material is less forgiving, but after decreasing the heat to 200°F, we could produce good parts. Still, material at 0.015" causes handling problems.

# ANSWER REPORTER'S QUESTIONS FOR CLARITY

An executive wrote the following email to a new newly hired employee

## BEFORE

Date: November 16, 2012  
To: Staff  
From: Earl Eddings, Manager  
Subject: Research

Please be prepared to plan a presentation on research. Make sure the information is very detailed.  
Thanks.

# AFTER

Date: November 16, 2012  
To: Melissa Hider  
From: Earl Eddings  
Subject: Research for Homeland Security Presentation

What

Who

Please make a presentation on homeland security for the Weston City Council. This meeting is planned for November 20, 2012, in Conference Room C, from 8:00 A.M.–5:00 P.M.

When

Where

We have a budget of \$6,000,000. Thus, to use these funds effectively, our city must be up to date on the following concerns:

Why

- Bomb-detection options
- Citizen preparedness
- Defense personnel training
- Crisis management

How

Use PowerPoint software to make your presentation. With your help, I know Weston and the Kansas City metro area will benefit.

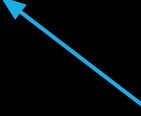
USE EASILY UNDERSTANDABLE WORDS FOR  
CLARITY

Avoid Obscure Words

The following rules are to be used when determining whether or not to duplicate messages:

- Do not duplicate nonduplicatable messages.
- A message is considered nonduplicatable if it has already been duplicated.

Your job duties will be to ensure that distributed application modifications will execute without abnormal termination through the creation of production JCL system testing.



Words like "nonduplicatable" and phrases like "execute without abnormal termination" are hard to understand. For clarity, write "do not duplicate secure messages" and "JCL system testing will ensure that applications continue to work."

## **OBSCURE WORDS**

aforementioned

initial

in lieu of

accede

as per your request

issuance

this is to advise you

subsequent

inasmuch as

ascertain

pursuant to

forward

cognizant

endeavor

remittance

disclose

attached herewith

pertain to

supersede

obtain

## **ALTERNATIVE WORDS**

discussed above

first

instead of

agree

as you requested

send

I'd like you to know

later

because

find out

after

mail

know

try

pay

show

attached

about

replace

get

## 2. CONCISENESS

Simplify words, sentences and paragraphs for conciseness

Conciseness saves time and resources

Conciseness aids clarity

Conciseness is desirable on electronic media

## LIMIT PARAGRAPH LENGTH

Ideally a paragraph should be between six to eight lines



# MEAT CLEAVER METHOD OF REVISION

Cut the sentence in half or thirds

## BEFORE

---

To maintain proper stock balances of respirators and canister elements and to ensure the identification of physical limitations that may negate an individual's previous fit-test, a GBC-16 Respirator Request and Issue Record will need to be submitted for each respirator requested for use.

## AFTER

---

Please submit a GBC-16 Respirator Request and Issue Record for each requested respirator. We then can maintain proper respirator and canister element stock balances. We also can identify physical limitations that may negate an individual's previous fit-test.

## LIMIT WORD LENGTH FOR CONCISENESS

When you need longer words, use them

BUT

Avoid words like “pursuant,” “accordance,”  
and “aforementioned

## BEFORE

---

I would like you to take into consideration the following points, which I know will assist you in better applying new HIPAA rules and regulations currently burdened by the need to execute all data manually and on paper rather than through standardized, electronic transmissions.

## AFTER

---

Please consider the following points. This will help you apply new HIPAA rules by submitting data online instead of having to type text on separate forms.

## BEFORE

### Long Words

utilize

anticipate

cooperate

indicate

initially

presently

prohibit

inconvenience

pursuant

endeavor

sufficient

subsequent

## AFTER

### Concise Version

use

await (or expect)

help

show

first (or 1.)

now

stop

problem

before

try

enough

next

# LIMIT SENTENCE LENGTH FOR CONCISENESS

## READABILITY

Very easy to read

Plain English

Extremely difficult to read

## LENGTH OF SENTENCES

Average sentence length is 12 words or less.

Average sentence length is 15 to 20 words.

Average sentence length exceeds 20 words.



# DELETE “BE” VERBS.

## BEFORE

### Wordiness Caused by “Be” Verbs

Bill *is* of the opinion that stock prices will decrease.

I *am* in receipt of your bill for \$1000.

If I can *be* of any assistance to you, please call.

They *are* planning to fax new invoices tomorrow.

Barb *had been* hoping to move into her new office complex today.

## AFTER

### Deleting for Conciseness

Bill thinks stock prices will decrease.

I received your \$1000 bill.

If I can help, please call.

They plan to fax new invoices tomorrow.

Barb hoped to move into her new office complex today.

## USE ACTIVE VOICE VERSUS PASSIVE VOICE.

### BEFORE

It *has been* decided that Joan Smith *will* head our Sales Department.

### AFTER

Larry named Joan Smith head of the Sales Department.



## DELETE THE EXPLETIVE PATTERN.

### BEFORE

---

*There are* three people who will work for Acme.

*It has been* decided that ten engineers will be hired.

### AFTER

---

Three people will work for Acme.

Ten engineers will be hired.

# AVOID CAMOUFLAGED WORDS

## BEFORE

### Camouflaged Words

make an *adjustment* of

have a *meeting*

*thanking you* in advance

for the purpose of *discussing*

arrive at an *agreement*

at a *later* moment

## AFTER

### Concise Versions

adjust (or revise, alter, change, edit, fix)

meet

thank you

discuss

agree

later

# AVOID PREPOSITIONAL PHRASES

## BEFORE

### Wordy Prepositional Phrases

He spoke *at a rapid rate*.

She wrote *with regard to* the meeting.

I will call *in the near future*.

*On two different occasions*, we met.

The manager *of personnel* was hired.

## AFTER

### Concise Versions

He spoke rapidly (or fast).

She wrote regarding (or about) the meeting.

I will call soon.

We met twice.

The personnel manager was hired.

# LIMIT PARAGRAPH LENGTH - FOUR TO SIX TYPED LINES

## BEFORE

Our project management approach will provide your city clear deliverables and meet your RFP criteria. Orlin & Sons proposes the following sequence. We will assess the adequacy of your current facilities from a technology perspective, starting on January 13, to be completed by February 1. Then, beginning on February 5, O&S will meet with residents' focus groups to identify community needs, including health, culture, history, and quality-of-life issues. This will allow us to identify necessary improvements to meet your current and ongoing requirements. We will complete this project milestone on February 25. The final step of the process involves setting team goals needed to work with city, county, and state regulatory agencies. We will begin this step on March 8 and conclude by March 15.



## AFTER

Our project management approach will provide your city clear deliverables and meet your RFP criteria. Orlin & Sons proposes the following sequence.

- Assess the adequacy of your current facilities from a technology perspective.

Begin/End Dates: 1/13–2/1

- Meet with residents' focus groups to identify community needs: health, culture, history, and quality-of-life issues.

Begin/End Dates: 2/5–2/25

- Set team goals needed to work with city, county, and state regulatory agencies.

Begin/End Dates: 3/8–3/15

### 3. ACHIEVING ACCURACY IN TECHNICAL COMMUNICATION

Correct grammar, mechanics and diction are vital

Dear Sr:

In response to your request, your account with use has been close out. We are submitted a check in the amount of \$468.72 (your existing balance). If you have any questions, please fill free to contact us.

Proofread your text

## PROOFREADING TIPS

Let someone else read it.

Let it sit.

Print it out.

Use technology.

Read it out loud.

## FAQs: The Importance of Proofreading

**Q: Is anyone in the workplace concerned about proofreading? Isn't proofreading just something that only English professors care about?**

**A:** Proofreading is essential in technical writing. Here are two stories to prove our point.

- One company paid \$120,000 in taxes for industrial equipment when only \$1,200 was owed. The writer had incorrectly placed the comma.
- A Chicago-based company purchased an industrial sander for \$54,589.62. Unfortunately, when listing the purchase on their year-end taxes, the company reported the purchase price as \$5,458,962. This misplaced decimal point and commas equaled a difference of over 5 million dollars. The issue is now in court, of course costing even more money.

A single mark of punctuation can be important.

*Source: Tony Rizzo, Kansas City Star*



## SOURCE

Technical Communication: Process and Product,  
8<sup>th</sup> Edition, by Sharon J. Gerson and Steven M.  
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